Outlook

[Draft] **Fw: DECO3500 Student Research – UQ History**

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From: Geoff Ginn <g.ginn@uq.edu.au>
Sent: Friday, August 28, 2026 3:51 PM
To: Keerthana Balamurugan <keerthanabalamurugan@student.uq.edu.au>
Cc: Lisa Featherstone <l.featherstone@uq.edu.au>
Subject: Re: DECO3500 Student Research – UQ History

Hello Keerthana,

Thanks for your email, this sounds like interesting work. Have you had many of the staff respond, based on your initial email? It is a busy time of year, and so they may take a little while to get back to you.

I am the History convenor, so I if you like I can follow up and encourage the others to respond.

My own thoughts on the questions you pose are below, in red.

Best wishes, Geoff

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Subject: DECO3500 Student Research – UQ History

Dear Dr Featherstone and colleagues,

My name is Keerthana Balamurugan, and I'm a Master of Interaction Design student at The University of Queensland currently working on a DECO3500 design project exploring how students engage with UQ's history.

Our team is investigating how we might help students, particularly new and international students, discover and engage with the cultural, Indigenous, architectural, political and social histories connected to the UQ campus.

Through our initial research, we have found that students can become curious about the history behind places they encounter on campus, but often don't know where to find this information or how to engage with it beyond formal resources. We are therefore exploring ways of making UQ's history more accessible, creative, engaging and connected to students' everyday experiences of the campus.

Given your expertise in History at UQ, we would really value your perspectives. We would be very grateful if you could answer the following questions by email. You certainly don't need to answer every question ; even a few thoughts would be extremely valuable to our project.

1. What aspects of UQ's history do you think students should know about but often don't?

The earlier location at Gardens Point

The circumstances of the shift to St Lucia (the Mayne bequest, and the falsity of the "Mayne Inheritance" myth - there is no evidence that Patrick Mayne murdered anybody!)

The vibrant campus culture in the 1960s-90s, and continuing vestiges of that today

4ZZZ and the alternative live music scene - Joint Efforts, etc.

The civil liberties and land rights campaigns that were based on campus

The Schonell cinema and cinephile life in Brisbane (only art house cinema around)

The Cement Box and Avalon theatres - drama and the avant garde

The influence of the UQ architecture school on Australian design, especially 1970s-2000s

2. Are there particular buildings, locations, objects or places on campus with significant or interesting historical stories that you think are currently overlooked by students?

Primarily the Student Union precinct - by contrast, the 'sandstone' destinations of the Great Court are well and truly represented in UQ marketing

3. Why do you think students may not engage with existing UQ historical resources or information?

To my mind that information is generally treated as marketing material, not as something that might capture things like idealism, activism, youthful creative energy.

4. What do you think makes a historical story meaningful or memorable to students, rather than simply informative?

The personal connection is hard to define, but a topic needs to have life and be relatable. Needs to tap into a sense of value, rather than just 'information' or even 'entertainment'. Important also to incorporate aesthetics and imagery.

5. Are there aspects of UQ's history that you think should be treated particularly carefully when being simplified, gamified or presented through an interactive experience?

I don't think we should be too solemn about the university's past - it is appropriate to respect earlier generations and activities, but also important to interrogate them within today's frame of reference, and that might include humour and irony.

6. Are there particular historical sources, collections, archives, oral histories or UQ resources that you would recommend we explore?

Campus culture is well represented in the Fryer Library collection.

7. If you could create one experience that would make a new UQ student genuinely curious about the university's history, what would you want that experience to be?

> **Something that captures the energy and vitality of student activism in the Vietnam War era, and from there into the 1970s and 1980s. Great music, great visuals, the sense of youthful creative energy mentioned above. The 1960s part has a lot of "boomer" cliche in it, but the 1970s activism is very significant in the context of the general conservatism and authoritarian politics of Queensland in the 1970s and 80s.**

Finally, if there are other people at UQ such as historians, Indigenous staff, archivists, librarians or community members , whom you think we should speak with, we would really appreciate any recommendations.

We understand that you are very busy, so please don't feel any pressure to provide lengthy responses. Any insights you are able to share would be greatly appreciated and will help us ensure that our design is grounded in accurate and respectful historical knowledge.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration.

Kind regards,
Keerthana Balamurugan
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DECO3500